



Although Bruegel's *Massacre of the Innocents* has a Biblical subject, in reality it is a commentary on Spanish brutality during the Dutch Revolt.

IN ESTABLISHING HIS OWN BRAND of divinely sanctioned Orthodox absolutism, **Ivan IV** (see panel, right) never had to contend with the substantial vested interests—mercantile, aristocratic, or clerical—that frustrated his counterparts in Western Europe. His principal opponents were the Cossacks—free-ranging frontiersmen—and the boyars, the

(see 1532) was to link them with the Philippines and the Spice Islands on the western extremity of the Pacific, which, in 1564, Spain determined to colonize. A westward route across the Pacific had been pioneered in 1527, but no return route was known. Between June and October 1565, Spanish navigator **Andrés de Urdaneta** made the critical breakthrough, sailing far to the north to find favorable winds in the **longest nonstop voyage yet made**—11,600 miles (18,700 km). It completed a **vital trade network**.

In much the same way that religious conflict and power politics in the French Wars of Religion produced a savage conflict, so the **Dutch Revolt**—which began in 1566 and lasted until 1648—was the product of a toxic mix of religious intolerance and a drive for political domination. In 1566, **Philip II of Spain, Catholic ruler of the Netherlands**, asserted: "I do not propose nor desire to be the ruler of heretics." Given that there was considerable support for a growing **Protestant** minority in the **Netherlands**, his divine obligation to eradicate these heresies was inescapable. But there was a further complication. The Netherlands, whether Protestant or Catholic, had no desire to submit to Philip's rule given that this would mean surrendering its own "liberties"—



IVAN THE TERRIBLE
(1530–84)

Though capable of bouts of remorse—as when, in 1581, he killed his eldest son and heir by staving in his head with a staff—Ivan IV applied a ruthless brutality to his rule. Hence Ivan "the Terrible". One key consequence was that vast numbers fled Russia during his reign from 1547 to 1584, depopulating the country to the point that serfdom (bonded peasantry) was the only means of retaining an agricultural workforce.

its right to govern itself even while acknowledging Philip as its overall ruler. In particular, it saw no reason why it should pay taxes to finance the Spanish king's campaigns elsewhere. While this was a problem that could never be resolved peacefully, even by the standards of the period, the resulting conflict was shockin in its violence (see 1572–73).



A priest blesses two soldiers in the Northern Rising of 1569, the last sustained attempt by Catholics in England to protest against the Reformation.

IN 1568, OMURA SUMIDATA, a Japanese *daimyo* who in 1563 had converted to Christianity, gave permission for Portuguese traders and missionaries to establish a port at a fishing village at the southern tip of Japan—**Nagasaki**. Until the suppression of Christianity in Japan in 1614, Nagasaki, a Jesuit colony, was not only almost entirely Catholic—or "kirishitan"—it was Portugal's most important trading center in East Asia.

The most urgent task facing **Akbar** in his consolidation of Mughal power in India (see 1555–56) was the defeat of the **Hindu Rajputs of the northwest**. This was a decade-long campaign, which climaxed in 1569 with the fall of the fortresses of Mewar and Ranthambore. Having secured the submission of the principal Rajput rulers, Akbar married a series of Hindu princesses (he had 36 wives in all), tying his defeated enemies to him in matrimonial alliances.

In 1569, the failure of **Sigismund II**, last of the Jagiellonian rulers of the Grand Duchy of Lithuania and of Poland, to produce an heir led to a formal union between the two states. This new **Polish–Lithuanian Commonwealth** became the **largest territorial state in Europe**. The move was prompted by Sigismund's desire to ensure that his dynasty's territories were preserved, and the need to protect Lithuania from the Ottomans and the Russians. The nobles of both territories quarreled over the new

constitutional arrangement, anxious it should not be to their disadvantage. For the **Poles**, the clinching factor was the **transfer to them of immense territories**, among them the **Ukraine**.

The **Northern Rising** of November 1569 was the **most serious threat to Elizabeth I's pragmatic Protestantism**. Led by the Catholic earls of Westmorland and Northumberland, it swept across northern England before being **savagely repressed**.

In 1569, the Flemish cartographer **Gerardus Mercator** (1512–94) devised a **world map** that for the first time showed the true compass bearing of every landmass. The **Mercator projection** remains the most familiar map of the world.



Gerardus Mercator
Mercator was an engraver and a mathematician as well as a skilled cartographer. He devised his world map of 1569 for marine navigation.

